



(LEFT) FAROOQ ABDULLAH WITH SON OMAR AFTER POLL RESULTS WERE ANNOUNCED; (BELOW LEFT) MUFTI MOHAMMAD SAYEED WITH DAUGHTER MEHBOOBA; JUBILANT BJP WORKERS (BELOW)

Ironically, it was such radical slogan pandering to ultra-Kashmiri sub-nationalism that helped the PDP buck the anti-incumbency factor and rather improve its tally from 16 to 21.

The pro-Hindutva groundswell in the aftermath of a protracted agitation over the Amarnath land row turned Hindu-dominated Jammu into a rich bounty for the BJP which won 11 seats, its highest-ever tally in the state. While the vote share of the centrist parties, the Congress and the NC, slumped across the state, the PDP and the BJP were the only gainers with their vote share surging 3 per cent and 10 per cent in Jammu and the Valley respectively. Though the separatists have been pushed to the sidelines, they and the PDP will be only waiting in the wings to cash in on the new government's blunders while the BJP would be volatile and vociferous in its long-standing de-



THE EUPHORIA IN BJP OVER THE 11 SEATS IT WON MAY BE MISPLACED: THE PARTY WON MORE SEGMENTS IN THE LAST TWO LOK SABHA ELECTIONS.

ernment in the state.

Projecting Omar as chief minister was a deft move by Farooq, born out of realpolitik given the junior Abdullah's "cordial chemistry" with Rahul Gandhi. In fact, Omar's appointment is seen as the first major decision that Rahul took since becoming AICC general secretary. Also, Omar reckons much common ground between the NC's agenda of "autonomy" and the Congress's poll plank of "devolution of powers" as a panacea for the Kashmir problem. In opting to prop up the NC-led Government, the Congress high command has nixed

overtures by its Kashmir-based leaders to forge an alliance with the second largest party and its previous coalition partner, the People's Democratic Party (PDP) headed by Mufti Mohammad Sayeed and his daughter Mehbooba Mufti. The bad blood created between the two after the PDP pulled the plug on the Ghulam Nabi Azad-led coalition government persists, and the two parties have drifted apart over the PDP's demand for "self-rule for Kashmir"—the centrepiece of the Muftis' political ideology which is beyond the ambit of the Indian Constitution.

mand for ending the 'discrimination' against Jammu.

Lacking his father's political charisma, Omar, however, will have to lean heavily on his experience to run what is a hot seat at the best of times. Currently, the state is awash with soaring expectations. Militancy is at the lowest ebb and separatism reduced to a mere ripple in the Kashmir Valley. But in the Valley where periods of relative calm have often been rudely shattered by bursts of separatism, Omar will have his hands full during his term as chief minister.

with Priya Sahgal